PRESS INFORMATION BUREAU
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

SHED DIFFERENCES OF RELIGION, CASTE AND PROVINCE

PRIME MINISTER'S CALL TO STAND UNITED

New Delhi, Sravana 24, 1904
August 15, 1982

The Prime Minister, Shrimati Indira Gandhi made today a strong plea to the people to rise above differences of religion, caste and province and stand united. She said some people are using these differences for political reasons and to get publicity. They are not interested in the welfare of the country. Smt. Gandhi was addressing the nation from the ramparts of the Red Fort here this morning on the occasion of the 36th Independence Day.

Smt. Gandhi reaffirmed the Government's commitment to banish poverty, ensure economic advancement and equitable distribution of the gains of industrialisation.

Smt. Gandhi said that we want that our industries should flourish, our agricultural production should grow, employment opportunities should increase and the production of those goods should increase whereby we can raise our living standards and gain comfort and happiness.

The following is...

PM'S INDEPENDENCE DAY SPEECH...

The following is the free rendering of the Prime Minister Smt. Indira Gandhi's speech in Hindi delivered here this morning from the ramparts of the Red Fort on the occasion of the 36th Independence Day:

"Brothers and sisters, I want to reach not only those who are sitting in front of me or the people of Delhi, but millions of our countrymen who are witnessing this occasion through INSAT and are participating with us in this happy occasion. Together with this I want my voice to reach those millions of my Indian brothers and sisters who are outside this country; who cannot listen to me either through radio or the INSAT but only through their hearts.

Today is our 36th Independence day, and we are standing in front of the historical Red Fort which throughout our history has been the symbol of our urge for Independence. From 1857 to the time when Gandhiji launched his non-violent movement and to the time Netaji Subhash Bose created an army, all Indians had but one desire: to see the flag of independent India flying on the Red Fort. Then 36 years ago Jawaharlal Nehru for the first time unfurled our flag here. His connection with the Red Fort had been established even earlier when he together with other brave people of the country had comeforth in defence of the people imprisoned at the Red Fort.

In a way, we can say that today is the day of tears; tears for those millions who gave their lives in our struggle for freedom, and, who struggled to safeguard this Independence. But this land is not a land of tears. Today is the day when we are proud.

we are proud of the fact that we did not let our vision become blurred because of tears, nor did we succumb to our injuries. Overcoming all dangers and difficultics, we have made progress whether it be in our struggle against an alien rule or the struggle to safeguard our borders or the struggle that we are facing today against poverty, economic backwardness and injustice. India has a tradition of overcoming its sorrows and marching forward with determination.

Today all of us - the farmers, the labour class, the unemployed women, the Scheduled Caste people, the backward classes, the tribals - all those who are still deprived of the fruits of independence and are not benefitted by industrialisation or modernity are all one in our struggle. If we have not been successful completely in our goals it is not because the desire was not there or the effort was not there, but because such gigantic tasks cannot be accomplished through magic or in a day. No matter how high we set our goals and how hard we try, such things take their own time. But if we remain united and show the same determination that we did during our struggle for independence, or that we do at times of external aggressi

we can certainly make quicker progress in our battle against poverty.

But I am sad to say that this determination is not always manifest. When we were under alien rule they exploited our greatest weakness, that is, to create dissensions among us in the name of religion or some such divisive factor. Thus they sought to sow the seeds of disunity and weaken

our fight for...

our fight for independence which we carried on through peaceful means under the leadership of Gandhiji. But we did not become victims of their machinations. There were occasional riots and disturbances but generally we progressed along our chosen path.

When we set forth on a journey, we come across all types of roads and paths. Some are wide, others are narrow and we have to select the path along which we want to move forward. Our country was a poverty-stricken and an oppressed country and under the circumstances we had only one path before us: the path of unity. We tried to create a society which would not fear oppression or succumb to suffering. There are many sitting before me who were born after independence and who cannot even imagine the humiliations we had to go through and the poverty that prevailed. Today we have poverty in the country but together with this the middle class has grown in numbers and has been strengthened. There is unemployment today but many people have also gained opportunities for better employment. The more we progress, the more such opportunities will increase.

Earlier we had to stretch our hands as beggars for food but today we produce enough food in our country. But the increase is not enough. With increase in population, we need more land for cultivation, more grains, more education and more health services. Things which we could not even dream of earlier, become necessities today for every person and every family. Our effort is to see that whatever little we have is so distributed that no one suffers. People may have a little less but there should be no injustice. Today who are

Today who are our enemies? May be that we have external enemies and may have them in future too. But we have our old enemy - poverty. Like many other countries, we also suffer from poverty and economic backwardness. What weakened us in the first place, because of which we lost our independence? The same thing exists today, which can and is weakening the country. These are the fissiparous tendencies in the name of religion, language, provincialism and casteism. I ask you, my brothers and sisters and dear children, which country has been able to progress without unity and hard work? We want our defence forces to be strong. Why? Not to launch an attack on others but to defend our own borders, to keep our country safe. We want that our industries should flourish, our agricultural production should grow, employment opportunities should increase and also the production of those goods which can help raise our living standards and provide comfort and happiness.

We are a peace loving nation and want that this atmosphere should prevail not only in our country but in the entire world. But when can this be possible? Only when rumour-mongering and injustices are curbed. We know that there are cases of injustice, oppression and corruption. But what is the way to overcome these? Can a weak government launch a struggle against these forces? Can a government

which itself is...

which itself is constantly under attack, keep safe the interests of the poor and of the minorities? Can a weak government build a country which can raise its head with pride in the whole world? Today the time has come to create a strong government, a strong nation. Of course, the time was always there but today this need is being felt all the more because, throughout the world, dangers have increased. The dangers and the difficulties which we, specially the poorer and the economically backward nations are trying to overcome, are existent more or less throughout the world. Even the richest and the strongest of nations are facing the problems of umemployment and inflation. In these countries too economic situation is not satisfactory. I have had the opportunity of visiting many countries . From other countries I or my ministers have not been able to visit, we constantly receive reports. Today all the countries are worried. And the greatest worry is the direction in which the human community is heading , after having increased its bounds of knowledge and ability. Are we heading for suicide and annhilation of this beautiful earth of ours? This is the question which is facing more and more people today. In world capitals and important towns there is a movement on the subject and people are thinking, writing and speaking about it.

There are three big dangers. One is the amassing of all kinds of arms and weapons which can destroy entire cities, buildings and land. Secondly, the gap between the rich and the poor nations...

poor nations continues to widen. This gap exists in our country and in other poor countries also. This is a fact we do not seek to conceal. At least we are trying to establish a socialistic pattern of society and socialism itself means that this difference between the rich and the poor should lessen: that equality should prevail in the society and that the fruits of independence should reach each individual and every family. The third danger is that because of today's greed we continue to exploit the natural resources of the earth like mining coal and extracting oil without giving a thought to what effect such acts will have on the coming generations.

We are proud of being Indians not because India is far more beautiful or better than other countries. Wherein then lies her greatness? What is that inherent quality which has seen her flourish through centuries and ages and which has imbued our poor people with a sense of strength and capability? It is essentially our age-old tradition of high ideals. Our country may have made mistakes but we have always set ourselves lofty goals. We have thought not merely in terms of India's unity but have viewed all issues in the context of humanity as a whole.

India has had a tradition of peace and tolerance: tolerance not only towards fellow-men but even towards animals and plants. This has been our tradition, whether you see the teachings of the Buddha or those of the Sikh gurus. You know how Emperor Asoka propagated his teachings of peace throughout the country and how Akbar brought together peoples of different

religions and ...

religions and profited from their teachings. Such things have given our country inherent strength.

Our independence day also coincides with the birth anniversary of Sri Aurobindo. Where in the world can you find the example of a revolutionary believing in violence giving up the violent path and turning to spritualism, all the while retaining his love for his country and seeking out ways to increase the inherent strength and morale of the nation. Then we had Gandhiji who assimilated all the best of various religions and forged the weapon of peace, friendship and a sense of brotherhood to fight for our independence. We were fighting our battle for independence but not with guns and canons. Our weapons were our unity, our patriotism and our dedication and determination to achieve the goal. Have we lost these weapons today? Does that sense of patriotism exist no more? Are we no more prepared to make sacrifices? I see many children sitting in front of me, and many young men must be listening at this moment to my voice. I call upon all those to join hands and be one in their patriotism to strengthen our nation. Today we are seeing provincialism on the rise. Those who take recourse to religion, caste and language for political gains, do not have the welfare of the nation at heart. There are people who imagine that progress can be achieved only through violence. This gets their names into the newspapers and creats a little stir. But we have to ask ourselves whether we want our names in print or we want

to strengthen the ...

to strengthen the country and work for its progress. Now is the time for you to choose your path. I am confident that our children, our elders who participated in the freedom struggle and those who fought in times of external aggression, will give evidence of the old spirit of unity and strength.

Today we have to strengthen the ancient values of India. We are all citizens of India and we should see that no act, no word and no thought of ours makes Mother India bow her head. We all have a tremendous responsibility on us, not only towards ourselves but also towards future generations. India is not a five or 10 or a 100 years' country. Her history goes back to thousands of years and it will continue to exist for thousands of years. That is why if I give a call to you to make sacrifices now it is for the sake of a better future. I have full confidence that no matter which ideology we subscribe to, and whatever political or other differences we may have, we will all be one when it comes to being soldiers for India. We do not adorn uniforms. We respect those who do and we take pride in them. But in our effort to make a better India, we are no less soldiers than them in carrying our struggle for progress. With this in view, I once again entreat you to be one: to remain strong and overcome difficulties with a cheer and a smile. We want our nation to be beautiful and should cleanse it of all dirt whether it is the dirt in the street, the dirt in our houses or in our hearts. Everybody has to voluntarily accept his own responsibility. We have

developed a habit.....

developed a habit of blaming others for our shortcomings. The only remedy for this is to ask ourselves if what we are doing is proper and whether we are preventing those who are doing the wrong thing? If the humblest of our citizens and also the most important thinks on these problems and realise his own responsibilities and changes accordingly, will not the entire society change, and with this, will not the entire nation change? This is a question which every one of us has to address to his own heart.

I once again felicitate you on this happy day and call upon you to be prepared for every suffering, every risk and every obstacle so that we can bring about a united India which can hold its head high in the community of nations.

JAI HIND."

OPK:SCK:SGL:RK:GS:JML:MPS:AK:MLS

253/10 (15-8-82) 15.35 hrs